because the reforms of the 1990s – when mass privatisation and the imposition of free-market rules transformed the economies – allowed too many former Communists to recycle their political power.' (I have described this painful process in the previous chapter.) Yet she also believes that this argument of the negative role of recycled former Communists 'which felt so important a quarter century ago, seems thin and superficial now.'[167] She thinks that populist politicians in Poland and Hungary are using 'restorative nostalgics' and are, above all, 'mythmakers and architects, builders of monuments and founders of nationalist political projects.'[168]

Poland and Hungary are the usual examples given of illiberal (Central) Europe. Other countries of the region seem to fare better – or perhaps it only seems so. Slovakia, despite the infamous case of the murder of an investigative journalist Ján Kuciak in 2018, is now better known for its liberal President Mrs Čaputová. (In the Netherlands too, an investigative journalist, Petr R. de Vries, was killed in Amsterdam in 2021, though it is true that no political connection to the murder was suggested. That was not the case with the murder of Maltese journalist Daphne Caruana Galizia in 2017. A sign of parallels and similarities between Eastern and Southern Europe?) Still, there are issues with the judiciary in Slovakia.[169] Baltic countries seem not to be particularly moved by populists: the agenda there is overwhelmed by the Russian threat, which continues to provide a shared base for national consensus. Still, the Estonian EKRE party received some prominence for its Eurosceptic and anti-elite stance.[170]

The case of the Czech Republic, the country in the region with the longest democratic tradition, is interesting. There, successive governments of (non-Communist) Social Democrats or liberal conservatives remained broadly aligned with the liberal democratic consensus, all the more so after the Russian aggression against Ukraine. Yet Mr Andrej Babiš, an ultra-rich businessman who appealed to very diverse groups of voters and was seen as a populist by many, twice served as Prime Minister and runs for President in 2023. By the same token, Miloš Zeman, the country's incumbent president, was up until the Russian invasion of Ukraine known for his pro-Russian and anti-immigrants stance.

In Croatia, power is often seen as being passed back and forth between a form of post-Communists and conservatives, both with strong patriotic